

Is Social Work Safe From AI?

The already-in-it guide — the full scores by track, the six factors behind them, and what to do from where you already are.

3.3

AI EXPOSURE · CHILD PROTECTION

where 10 is most at risk

For anyone already in it — in the degree, or job-hunting.



Before you read this

The choice is already made — you're in a social work degree or training, or out of one and into the job hunt. So this guide skips the "should you study social work" question and goes straight to the one that's actually live: given where you already are, what do you do about it?

It's written to you directly — whether you are the one in it, or a parent reading on their behalf. Where it says "you," a parent can simply read "them"; the moves are the same either way.

What this is. A facts document, not a pep talk. It sets out what's known about where social work sits in an AI economy, where the evidence is contested, and where we might be wrong — and then what to actually do from here.

The good news, up front. Already in it is not too late — not close. On the technology question social work is about as secure as work gets, and social work isn't one destination but a wide spread of them, from 3.3 to 6.1. Where you land inside that range is decided mostly by moves still in front of you — chiefly which setting you steer toward. The second half of this guide is those moves.

And one thing specific to social work. The AI answer here is genuinely reassuring, and the honest answer about the working conditions is difficult. The section on what's genuinely hard sets out what the research says about burnout, caseloads and trauma exposure in child welfare specifically, and it isn't comfortable reading. It's here because you deserve the real picture, and because the profession's own bodies publish this data precisely so it can be addressed. It is not a reason to leave social work. It is a reason to choose the setting deliberately, which matters more here than in almost any career we score — and that choice is still in front of you.

The short answer

Yes — and statutory social work carries the single most durable protection we measure anywhere.

Statutory child protection scores **3.3** out of 10. Adult safeguarding scores **3.8**. Policy and program administration scores **6.1**.

The protection isn't a license. It's delegated state authority — the legal power to remove a child, restrict a liberty, or compel an intervention. That power is vested in a named human by statute, and there is no mechanism by which a system could hold it.

The real considerations are pay, caseloads and emotional load — and those are serious.

The scores

TRACK	2023	2025	FALL 2026	3-YR MOVEMENT	BAND
Statutory child protection	2.8	3.1	3.3	+0.5	Low
Adult safeguarding (statutory)	3.2	3.5	3.8	+0.6	Low
Clinical social work (LCSW)	3.6	4.0	4.3	+0.7	Low
Medical / hospital social work	4.0	4.4	4.7	+0.7	Moderate
Community / case management	4.6	5.0	5.4	+0.8	Moderate
Policy & program administration	5.2	5.7	6.1	+0.9	Moderate-High

Scores run 1–10, where 10 is most at risk. For context: the median profession in this edition sits around 5.5, bedside nursing scores 2.8, classroom teaching 3.6, licensed clinical psychology 3.5, and entry-level software development 8.1.

Read the table this way: the statutory tracks score best, and they score best for a reason that has nothing to do with how hard the work is to do. It's about who the law permits to do it — and which of these tracks you end up in is decided mostly by moves still in front of you.

Statutory authority is not the same as a license

This is the most important idea in this guide, and it completes an argument that runs through several others in this index.

We've made the case repeatedly that a license is only as protective as the act it reserves. Pharmacy's license reserves dispensing, which automates readily. Law's bar card reserves the courtroom but not document review. Nursing's license reserves hands-on clinical practice, which couldn't be automated anyway.

Statutory social work is a different category again, and a stronger one.

An ordinary professional license says: *this act may only be performed by a qualified person*. It is a restriction on who may do the work.

Statutory social work authority says something else entirely: the state has delegated a coercive power to a named individual. A social worker in a statutory role can initiate the removal of a child from their parents, apply for orders that restrict an adult's liberty, and make findings that carry legal force.

Three things follow, and they're worth understanding precisely.

It cannot be delegated to a system, even in principle. A license could conceivably be rewritten to permit machine performance of a licensed act — legislatures have done that before in other fields. But delegated coercive authority requires a person who can be held accountable, questioned in court, and subjected to professional sanction. There is no accountable subject for a system to be.

It is embedded in the deepest kind of law. Child protection powers sit in primary legislation and are subject to judicial oversight, human rights considerations and public inquiry. That is the slowest-moving legal architecture there is.

And it is expanding rather than contracting. Safeguarding obligations have broadened consistently over two decades across adult social care, domestic abuse and modern slavery.

The general lesson: when you assess any career's regulatory protection, ask what kind it is. A certification requirement is weak. A reserved professional act is stronger. Delegated state authority over another person's liberty is the strongest protection in this entire index — and almost nobody thinks of social work in those terms.

Why social work scores low — the six factors



Here's how statutory child protection answers them — and knowing *why* the statutory tracks hold near the top of the table while policy and administration drift toward 6.1 is what tells you which way to move.

HOW MUCH OF THIS JOB CAN AI ALREADY DO? (35% OF THE SCORE)

A great deal of the recording — which is more than half the job — and none of the practice.

Case notes and recording. Report drafting for court and panels. Referral triage. Eligibility and threshold checking. Resource and service matching. Statutory return compilation.

The federal Office of Planning, Research and Evaluation found that paperwork and outdated technology consume an average of **4.3 hours of a caseworker's eight-hour day**. That is more than half the working day on administration, and it is the profession's leading complaint.

What resists: sitting in a family's home and forming a judgment about whether a child is safe; building enough trust with someone who does not want you there; deciding to act on incomplete information when both action and inaction carry serious risk; and carrying the legal accountability for that decision. Those are the things to be building toward.

HOW HARD WILL IT BE TO LAND THAT FIRST JOB? (15%)

Among the easiest entries we measure, and that is partly a symptom rather than only a benefit. Vacancies are widespread, turnover is high, and employers are actively recruiting — the section on what's genuinely hard explains why.

But easy entry is a fork, not a green light. The vacancies are easiest to fill exactly where the conditions are hardest — the child-welfare roles with the highest turnover — so taking whatever seat is open is not the same as landing in a career you'll stay in. The way through is to

treat the setting and the *employer* as the real decision: ask about caseloads and supervision before accepting, aim at the statutory and licensed tracks that carry the durable protection, and understand that with turnover around 30% and median tenure of 1.8 years, choosing where you start is choosing whether you stay. Those are concrete moves, and the career-hunting checklist later in this guide lays them out.

DOES IT HAVE TO BE DONE IN PERSON, WITH YOUR HANDS? (15%)

Substantially. Home visits, direct observation, being physically present in a house to assess whether it is safe. Much of the core assessment work cannot be done remotely, and that was tested at scale during the pandemic with poor results.

DOES SOMEONE NEED A HUMAN THEY CAN TRUST AND HOLD RESPONSIBLE? (15%)

Yes, and in both directions at once. A family must be able to trust the worker enough to disclose; and when a decision goes wrong, a named human is answerable to a court, an inquiry and a professional body.

DOES THE LAW REQUIRE A LICENSED HUMAN? (10%)

We rate this 9.5 — the joint highest in the index, for the reasons in the section on statutory authority.

HOW OFTEN DOES THE JOB HIT GENUINELY NEW, HIGH-STAKES SITUATIONS? (10%)

Constantly. Every family is different, the information is always incomplete, and the consequences of being wrong are severe in both directions. The distance between the statutory decision-maker who carries that and the administrator who never will is the distance you're trying to close.

What the trend shows

Statutory child protection: 2.8 → 3.1 → 3.3. Up 0.5 in three years — among the slowest movements in the index, and entirely administrative.

Policy and administration: 5.2 → 5.7 → 6.1. Up 0.9.

The gap widened from 2.4 points to 2.8. The pattern holds exactly: the further from the family and the statutory decision, the higher the exposure climbs.

How durable is the protection?

PROTECTION	STRENGTH TODAY	DURABILITY	WHERE THE PRESSURE IS COMING FROM
Regulatory / statutory authority	Joint highest in the index	The most durable protection we score	Delegated coercive power requires an accountable person. No mechanism exists to transfer it.
Human trust / accountability	Very strong	Durable	Families must trust enough to disclose; someone must answer to a court.
Judgment under novelty	Very strong	Durable	Every family is different and the information is always incomplete.
Physical / embodied	Strong for statutory work	Durable	Home visits and direct observation cannot be done remotely.

The honest read. Statutory social work has all four protections operating together, with the strongest regulatory protection in the index. On the technology question, this is about as secure as work gets.

How the role will actually change

WAS THE JOB	IS BECOMING THE JOB
Writing up case notes after every visit	Reviewing a generated draft
Drafting court and panel reports	Drafted, then checked and owned
Compiling statutory returns	Automated
Triaging referrals against thresholds	Pre-triaged; the worker adjudicates
Chasing services and resources	Matched automatically
Sitting in a family's home	Unchanged
Deciding whether a child is safe	Unchanged

This is the clearest case in the index of automation targeting the right layer. 4.3 hours of an eight-hour day is administration. The profession's own research names administrative burden as one of five documented drivers of burnout — and it is the one an agency can fix without new legislation or new funding.

Two honest caveats. Verification becomes a genuine safeguarding responsibility — a generated case note that misrepresents a visit is a child-safety issue, not a clerical one. And time saved may be absorbed by larger caseloads rather than returned, which is a funding decision rather than a technological one.

Human strengths that will matter most

1. **Judging safety in a real home** — reading a situation, a room, a relationship. The least automatable thing in this profession. 2. **Building trust with people who don't want you there** — often the whole determinant of whether a case goes well. 3. **Carrying statutory accountability** — being the named human who decided. 4. **Deciding under genuine uncertainty** where both acting and not acting carry serious risk. 5. **Verification** — knowing when a generated record doesn't reflect what actually happened.

And underneath all five, two traits the score can't grade: **curiosity and adaptability.** The specific tools — the recording system, the referral-triage engine, the risk-prediction model — will turn over many times across a career. The social workers who compound are the ones who stay genuinely curious about the families in front of them and re-tool fastest, rather than defending the one way of working they trained on. In a profession where the automatable layer is the paperwork and the protected layer is the judgment made in a real home, that flexibility is itself a form of protection — and increasingly it's what agencies value: the practitioner who keeps learning, not the one who mastered one system.

Other things to consider about this job

What's genuinely good about it

Demand is strong and growing across every specialization. BLS projects social work employment growing 6% from 2024 to 2034, with healthcare social work at 8% and mental health and substance abuse social work at 10%.

And the need is acute in a way that translates directly into employment: roughly 40% of the US population lives in a federally designated mental health professional shortage area — rising to 97% in Texas and 72% of counties in Minnesota.

Pay is better than the profession's reputation suggests, and varies a lot by specialism. BLS median across social workers is \$61,330 (May 2024), with the top 10% above \$99,500. Healthcare social work leads at \$68,090, mental health and substance abuse at \$60,060, and child, family and school work lowest at around \$53,940.

And licensed clinical social workers in private practice report \$75,000 to over \$125,000 in urban markets — the highest-earning route in the profession, though it takes time to build.

Public Service Loan Forgiveness applies to most of the sector, which materially changes the debt arithmetic compared with other helping professions.

What social workers report as rewarding is unusually consistent: the work is straightforwardly worth doing; you see change in individual lives; the variety is real; and few careers offer this much responsibility this early.

What's genuinely hard about it

This is the section that matters, and the research is unambiguous.

Caseloads. In child welfare, caseloads commonly run far above recommended levels — the recommended standard is roughly 15 and actual loads frequently reach three times that.

Burnout and trauma exposure. The federal Office of Planning, Research and Evaluation's 2025 workforce snapshot found nearly 80% of child welfare caseworkers reporting some level of burnout. The Child Welfare League of America's workforce research found 63.7% reporting moderate burnout, 49.6% reporting moderate secondary trauma, and 26.2% meeting diagnostic criteria for PTSD.

Turnover, and what it means. National child welfare caseworker turnover runs around 30% a year, ranging from 20% to 60% by agency — roughly six times the average for other occupations. Casey Family Programs identifies 12% or below as healthy. Median tenure is around 1.8 years, and most turnover happens within the first two years.

Read that last figure carefully, because it has a specific implication: most child welfare caseworkers leave before they have been fully trained. That is a workforce problem before it is a personal one, and it means a new worker's colleagues are often nearly as inexperienced as they are.

Pay relative to responsibility is the most-cited grievance, particularly in child welfare where the responsibility is greatest and the pay is lowest.

And a 2026 Government Accountability Office report found a majority of state child welfare agencies reporting ongoing staffing challenges — this is a documented national problem, not a local one.

None of this is a reason not to do social work. It is the reason the rest of this guide keeps insisting you choose the setting deliberately.

Who this work suits — and who it doesn't

Social work tends to suit people who:

- **Can sit with distress without absorbing it** — the single most important trait, and the best predictor of who stays
- **Are comfortable being unwelcome.** Statutory work often means being in a home where nobody wants you.
- **Can hold uncertainty and still decide** — both action and inaction carry risk
- **Are organised**, because the recording burden is real even after automation
- **Have genuine support outside work** — this matters more here than in almost any career

It's harder for people who:

- **Need to fix things.** Many situations don't resolve, and some get worse.
- **Take work home emotionally** without a way to put it down
- Need **predictable, contained** workloads
- Are drawn to it primarily to **help** without understanding that statutory work is often about authority rather than assistance

If some of that second list sounds like you, it isn't necessarily a reason to leave — but it is a reason to be deliberate about which setting you steer toward, and about the support you build around the work.

What else is moving this market

The setting matters more than the profession, and by a wide margin. Child welfare has the highest turnover and the lowest pay; healthcare social work has the highest pay and the second strongest growth; clinical private practice has the highest ceiling. These are genuinely different careers sharing a qualification.

Licensure pathways are being reformed in several states to address workforce shortages, which affects how quickly you reach clinical practice.

And integration into healthcare is the growth story — social work is increasingly embedded in primary care and accountable care models, which is where the 8% and 10% growth figures come from.

The AI-native advantage — what it actually looks like

The situation: this may be the profession in the entire index where automation most directly addresses the documented cause of people leaving. Being already in it, close to the work, is a real advantage here — you can build this fluency inside a placement or a first job, which is exactly where it counts.

WHAT AN AI-NATIVE SOCIAL WORKER LOOKS LIKE

- 1. Reclaim the 4.3 hours deliberately.** Administrative burden is one of five documented burnout drivers and the only one an agency can change without new legislation or funding. A worker who is intentional about where that time goes gets the benefit; one who isn't watches caseloads absorb it.
- 2. Verify.** A generated case note that misrepresents a home visit is a safeguarding failure. This is a professional responsibility, not a clerical one.
- 3. Understand the risk-prediction question.** Predictive analytics in child welfare is already deployed in some jurisdictions and is genuinely contested — questions of bias, transparency and accountability are live. A practitioner who understands both the statistics and the practice is unusually valuable, and there are very few of them.
- 4. Keep the authority visible.** Everything in this guide points at statutory accountability. Roles that carry it are protected; roles that support it are less so.
- 5. Contribute to how the tools are implemented.** Agencies are procuring these systems now, mostly without frontline input.

All five are available to you now — not after some future qualification. Turning them into concrete moves is the rest of this guide.

Where a social work qualification can lead later

Statutory child and adult social work, clinical practice and private therapy, healthcare and hospital social work, school social work, substance misuse and mental health services, policy and commissioning, service management, safeguarding leadership, and academia.

The pattern in this index holds: the further from statutory decision-making and direct practice, the higher the exposure. Policy and program administration scores 6.1 against statutory child protection at 3.3. That pattern is the compass for every choice below.

Repositioning from here

The program-selection stage is behind you. The useful questions now are different — and the good news bears repeating: where you land inside this profession is decided mostly by moves still in front of you. Social work is a 2.8-point spread from 3.3 to 6.1, and, on the technology question, even the exposed end is only moderate. Nearly every move points the same way: toward a setting that carries statutory authority or the LCSW license — and toward an employer you can actually survive.

If you're still in the degree or training

Three levers, in order of leverage.

1. The setting is the whole game. Not "social work" but *which* social work: child welfare, healthcare, clinical practice are genuinely different careers sharing one qualification — with genuinely different scores (statutory child protection 3.3 and adult safeguarding 3.8 at the protected end; community / case management 5.4 and policy / program administration 6.1 more exposed) and genuinely different conditions. If you haven't chosen a setting deliberately, this is the single highest-leverage decision left.

2. Placements are where you choose it. Treat placements as the decision, not the assessment. The setting shapes this career more than the qualification does, and placement — especially a statutory placement — is where you find out which setting suits you and build the on-ramp into it. While it's still free to explore, aim at the placement that opens the track you want, not just the one that's easiest to get.

3. Aim at the track that carries real authority. The protection here is delegated state authority (statutory work) and, at the highest-earning end, the LCSW license (+2 years supervised, scoring 4.3). Both attach accountability to a named person, and that is the whole source of the protection. Steer toward those tracks rather than the community / case-management and

policy tiers that feed them — that's the difference between the protected end of the table and the exposed one.

If you've graduated and you're job-hunting

Here the setting and the employer matter more than the offer, because the easiest roles to get are often the hardest to stay in.

- **Community / case management (5.4) and policy / administration (6.1) are the more exposed end.** They're common early destinations and the more automatable layer at once. Taking one isn't fatal — but if statutory or clinical practice is the aim, take it as a deliberate stepping-stone with an exit in mind, not as the plan.
- **Aim at the statutory and clinical tracks (3.3, 3.8, 4.3).** They carry the durable protection, and proximity to the decision someone is accountable for is proximity to it.
- **Choose the employer, not just the role.** Ask about caseload numbers and supervision frequency at interview, and treat evasive answers as an answer. With turnover around 30% and median tenure of 1.8 years, choosing the employer is choosing whether you stay in the profession — more than the setting even.
- **Use the debt arithmetic.** Public Service Loan Forgiveness applies across most of the sector, which changes what a lower headline salary in a protected, well-supervised role actually costs you.

The AI-native move, from where you stand

You can't change how the tools are arriving, but you can be the practitioner who directs them rather than being managed by them. The five capabilities above are all available right now, inside a placement or a first job. The most powerful for someone already in it is the third: **understanding the risk-prediction question well enough to hold both the statistics and the practice.** Predictive analytics is already being deployed in child welfare and is genuinely contested — bias, transparency, accountability — and a practitioner who understands both sides is unusually valuable precisely because there are so few of them. That's a differentiator you can start building this term, inside whatever placement or role you're in, not after some future qualification.

The career-hunting checklist

The analysis tells you where the exposure is. This is what to do about it — the part that's actually in your hands. Most of the protection in social work is built here, in these choices, rather than

handed to you. The first list is for anyone still in the degree or training; the second is for the job hunt itself.

During the degree / training — build toward the protected tracks

- **Treat the setting as the decision, not the degree.** The protection in social work lives at the statutory and clinical tiers (statutory child protection 3.3, adult safeguarding 3.8, clinical / LCSW 4.3, medical / hospital 4.7), not in the community / case-management (5.4) or policy / administration (6.1) tiers. Aim every choice at a track that carries statutory authority or the LCSW license.
- **Treat placements as the real decision.** The setting shapes this career more than the qualification does, and placement — especially a statutory placement — is where you find out which setting suits you and how to get into it. Chase the placement that opens the track you want.
- **Get real exposure to people in difficulty early.** Support work, care work, helpline volunteering. It answers the fit question faster than anything else, and it's what the good programs want to see.
- **Get fluent with the tools as a practitioner, not a shortcut.** Learn to verify a generated case note — a misrepresented visit is a safeguarding failure, not a clerical error — and understand the predictive-analytics debate in child welfare: bias, transparency, accountability.
- **Plan to reclaim the 4.3 hours deliberately once you're in the job.** Administrative burden is one of five documented burnout drivers and the only one an agency can fix without new law or new money — so being intentional about where that time goes is a survival skill, not just an efficiency one.
- **Feed curiosity and adaptability on purpose.** The tools will turn over repeatedly; the social worker who re-tools fastest, and stays genuinely curious about the families in front of them, compounds.
- **Keep the frame wide.** Properly vet healthcare social work (highest pay, 8% projected growth), the LCSW route (4.3), and statutory routes before committing. They are genuinely different careers sharing a qualification.

During the job hunt — choose the setting and the employer, don't just apply

- **Target the protected tracks on purpose.** Statutory child protection and adult safeguarding, clinical / LCSW practice — not "any social work role," which too often lands in the highest-turnover setting.

- **Read the title and the setting, not just the offer.** Community / case management and policy / administration (5.4, 6.1) are the more exposed end. If you take one, take it as a deliberate stepping-stone with an exit in mind, not as the plan.
- **Don't grab a role just because it's on offer in an exposed lane.** A role being available doesn't make it safe. An employer still building out a large administrative or case-coordination function that automation is starting to absorb may simply be behind the curve — and that's exactly the layer that gets cut first once it catches up. Availability can be a lagging indicator, not a green light.
- **Choose the employer, not just the role.** Ask about caseload numbers and supervision frequency at interview, and treat evasive answers as an answer. With turnover around 30% and median tenure of 1.8 years, choosing the employer is choosing whether you stay in the profession.
- **Prefer proximity to statutory decision-making.** Roles that carry accountability — statutory authority, the LCSW signature — score better than roles that support them. Aim at the seat that decides, not the one that feeds it.
- **Ask the employer where AI is heading in the role.** Whether they're using it to return the 4.3 hours to practice or to absorb them into bigger caseloads tells you whether the seat grows or is quietly being hollowed out.
- **Weigh trajectory and conditions over starting pay** — and note that Public Service Loan Forgiveness applies across most of the sector, which changes the debt arithmetic in ways a headline salary doesn't show.

Go deeper — further reading

- **Social Workers — Occupational Outlook Handbook** — US Bureau of Labor Statistics. Median pay by specialism, projected growth and entry requirements. Free, and the source for every wage figure above. The variation between specialisms is the most useful thing in it.
- **Child Welfare Workforce research** — Child Welfare League of America. The burnout, secondary trauma and turnover figures in the section on what's genuinely hard. Uncomfortable and important, and published by the sector itself precisely so it can be addressed.
- **OPRE child welfare workforce research** — Office of Planning, Research and Evaluation, US Department of Health and Human Services. Federal research including the finding that administration consumes 4.3 hours of an eight-hour caseworker day.

The counterargument — read this one:

The strongest case against our 3.3 isn't that AI will replace statutory social workers. It's that a very low AI score may lead someone to under-weight the conditions that actually drive people out.

Median tenure of 1.8 years. Turnover around six times the occupational average. Nearly 80% of child welfare caseworkers reporting burnout and over a quarter meeting diagnostic criteria for PTSD. On this reading, being told that social work is "protected" is true and close to irrelevant — the risk here was never automation.

Where we land: entirely fair, and it's why the section on what's genuinely hard is the longest here. Our score measures automation exposure and nothing else. For social work specifically, the technology answer is genuinely good news — the automation is removing 4.3 hours of daily paperwork, which is one of the five documented burnout drivers — and the conditions answer is genuinely hard. Conflating them would be the most damaging thing this document could do.

Bottom line

Statutory social work carries the most durable protection in this index, and it is a protection almost nobody recognises — which is exactly why being already in it is not a problem. The decisive moves were always going to happen from here.

It isn't a license. It's delegated state authority — the legal power to remove a child or restrict an adult's liberty, vested in a named human who can be questioned in court. There is no mechanism by which a system could hold that power, because there is no accountable subject for a system to be.

And the automation arriving is targeted at exactly the right layer. Administration consumes 4.3 hours of an eight-hour caseworker day, and it is named in the profession's own research as one of five burnout drivers — and the only one an agency can fix without new law or new money.

The honest difficulties are severe and have nothing to do with technology. Turnover around six times the occupational average, median tenure of 1.8 years, and burnout and trauma figures that the sector publishes precisely because they need addressing.

So the useful advice isn't a verdict on the degree — it's a direction. Choose the setting deliberately, because child welfare, healthcare social work and clinical practice are genuinely

different careers sharing one qualification. Steer toward the statutory and clinical tracks that carry the durable protection. Choose the employer as carefully as the role — ask about caseloads and supervision, and treat evasion as an answer. Use the fact that PSLF applies across most of the sector. And build real AI fluency now, inside whatever role you're in, because that's a differentiator this profession will increasingly reward.

And one thing worth saying plainly. Social work is among the small number of careers where the work is straightforwardly worth doing, and where the thing protecting it is that society decided only a person should hold this kind of power. That's a good reason to be in it — and the conditions above are a good reason to be deliberate about where.

Questions worth sitting with

Whether you're the one in it or a parent thinking it through, these are the conversations that move the needle now. Read "you" as whoever the decision is about.

Where you actually stand

1. Which setting are you in or aiming at — and does it point at statutory authority or the LCSW signature (3.3, 3.8, 4.3), or at the community / case-management and policy tiers (5.4, 6.1) that feed them? 2. Looking at the score table, which track are you currently pointed at, and is it the one you'd choose on purpose? 3. **Do you understand that statutory work is often about authority rather than assistance?** It's the most common misapprehension about this career, and worth being honest about now.

The move from here

4. What's the single most protected track you could realistically move toward from where you are now — statutory practice, the LCSW route — and what would make you a credible candidate for it? 5. If you're still studying: are your placements pointed at the setting you actually want, or just at whatever's available? Is there a statutory placement you could still aim for? 6. If you're job-hunting: are you choosing the employer as carefully as the role? Do you know the caseload numbers and supervision frequency for the jobs you're chasing?

The AI question, practically

7. Of the five capabilities — reclaim the 4.3 hours, verify, understand risk prediction, keep the authority visible, contribute to implementation — which one could you visibly demonstrate

within the next few months? 8. Have you looked at how predictive analytics or AI-assisted recording is used in the settings you're considering? Could you hold both the statistics and the practice in a conversation about it?

Testing it against reality

9. **The most valuable single action:** find a social worker three to five years in — past the median tenure — and ask what kept them, and which setting and employer decisions made the difference. 10. If the first offer that comes is a case-management or administrative role, what's your plan — take it as a deliberate stepping-stone with an exit in mind, or hold out for something closer to statutory or clinical practice? Decide before the offer, not after.

This is analysis and informed judgment about a fast-moving situation. For social work specifically, we've flagged that the profession's most serious risks are working conditions rather than technology, and that they vary enormously by setting — something our six factors cannot see.

Scores for 2023 and 2025 are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology. Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed.

Technical scoring appendix — Social Work

Pivotum Degree Risk Index — Fall 2026 Edition

This appendix is the audit trail. It sets out the formula, the rating anchors, every factor rating behind every track score in this profile, the backcast arithmetic, a sensitivity analysis, and the specific things that would change our mind.

We publish it because a score nobody can check is an opinion with a decimal point.

1. The formula

$$\begin{aligned} \text{Risk} = & 0.35 \times \text{Automatability} \\ & + 0.15 \times \text{EntryErosion} \\ & + 0.15 \times (10 - \text{Physical}) \\ & + 0.15 \times (10 - \text{Trust}) \\ & + 0.10 \times (10 - \text{Regulatory}) \\ & + 0.10 \times (10 - \text{Judgment}) \end{aligned}$$

Two exposure factors carry 50% of the weight; three protection factors carry 40%; judgment under novelty carries the remaining 10% and sits on the protection side. The deliberate consequence is that protection can outweigh exposure — which is why a highly automatable job like teaching still scores low.

Bands. Very low below 3.0 · Low 3.0–4.4 · Moderate 4.5–5.4 · Moderate–High 5.5–6.9 · High 7.0 and above.

2. Rating anchors

HOW THE 0–10 RAW RATINGS ARE ANCHORED

Every factor is rated on its own 0–10 scale before weighting. The anchors are identical across all twenty-eight careers, which is what makes the scores comparable.

Task automatability (A) — *what share of the working week could a capable current system already do to an acceptable standard?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Almost nothing. The work is physical, relational or wholly novel.
3–4	Administrative surround only — notes, scheduling, correspondence.
5–6	A meaningful minority of the week, mostly documentation and lookup.
7–8	A large share, including tasks central to the junior version of the role.
9–10	Most of the described duties, at or near professional standard.

Entry-path erosion (E) — *how much has the traditional route into this work narrowed?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Protected by statute or physical necessity. Training hours cannot be automated.
3–4	Stable. Some junior tasks absorbed; the apprenticeship survives.
5–6	Visible narrowing. Employers prefer experience; junior intake reduced.
7–8	Substantial. The work juniors learned on has largely gone.
9–10	The training layer and the automatable layer were the same layer.

Physical / embodied (P) — *must this be done in person, with a body, in an unpredictable setting?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Fully screen-based. Location-independent.
3–4	Occasional presence; the core work is not physical.
5–6	Regular physical presence, in largely controlled conditions.
7–8	Substantially physical, with some variability of setting.
9–10	Irreducibly physical, in conditions that differ every time.

Human trust / accountability (T) — *does someone need a specific human they can rely on, and must a human answer when it goes wrong?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Output is anonymous and reviewed by others.
3–4	Work is signed off by someone else. No personal reliance.
5–6	Some client relationship; accountability is institutional.
7–8	Named responsibility, with commercial or professional consequence.
9–10	The relationship is the service, and liability attaches personally.

Regulatory / licensing (R) — *does the law reserve this act to a qualified human?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	No license exists and none is proposed.
3–4	Certification is customary but not reserved.
5–6	Partial reservation, varying by jurisdiction or task.
7–8	Licensed practice, with some unreserved adjacent work.
9–10	Comprehensive statutory reservation, including of the training route.

Judgment under novelty (J) — *how often does the work present something with no matching precedent, where being wrong is costly?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Routine by design. Deviation is an error, not a case.
3–4	Occasional exceptions, handled by escalation.
5–6	Regular non-standard cases within a known range.
7–8	Frequent genuine novelty with material consequences.
9–10	Novelty is constant, and in some fields adversarially generated.

3. Factor ratings by track

Ratings are the Fall 2026 edition unless a range is shown. **P, T, R and J are held constant across editions** — those protections are structural and do not move on a three-year horizon. All measured movement is in A and E.

STATUTORY CHILD PROTECTION — 3.3 (LOW)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	6.2	6.9	7.4	2.59
Entry-path erosion	15%	1.5	1.8	2.0	0.3
Physical / embodied	15%	8.5	8.5	8.5	0.22
Human trust / accountability	15%	9.5	9.5	9.5	0.07
Regulatory / licensing	10%	9.5	9.5	9.5	0.05
Judgment under novelty	10%	9.5	9.5	9.5	0.05
				Total	3.29 → 3.3

ADULT SAFEGUARDING (STATUTORY) — 3.8 (LOW)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	6.8	7.6	8.4	2.94
Entry-path erosion	15%	1.8	2.0	2.2	0.33
Physical / embodied	15%	8.0	8.0	8.0	0.3
Human trust / accountability	15%	9.3	9.3	9.3	0.1
Regulatory / licensing	10%	9.5	9.5	9.5	0.05
Judgment under novelty	10%	9.2	9.2	9.2	0.08
				Total	3.8 → 3.8

CLINICAL SOCIAL WORK (LCSW) — 4.3 (LOW)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	6.9	7.9	8.7	3.04
Entry-path erosion	15%	2.2	2.5	2.8	0.42
Physical / embodied	15%	6.5	6.5	6.5	0.53
Human trust / accountability	15%	9.3	9.3	9.3	0.1
Regulatory / licensing	10%	9.0	9.0	9.0	0.1
Judgment under novelty	10%	8.8	8.8	8.8	0.12
				Total	4.31 → 4.3

MEDICAL / HOSPITAL SOCIAL WORK — 4.7 (MODERATE)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	7.4	8.4	9.1	3.18
Entry-path erosion	15%	2.5	2.8	3.0	0.45
Physical / embodied	15%	6.0	6.0	6.0	0.6
Human trust / accountability	15%	9.0	9.0	9.0	0.15
Regulatory / licensing	10%	8.5	8.5	8.5	0.15
Judgment under novelty	10%	8.5	8.5	8.5	0.15
				Total	4.69 → 4.7

COMMUNITY / CASE MANAGEMENT — 5.4 (MODERATE)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	7.5	8.5	9.4	3.29
Entry-path erosion	15%	3.0	3.4	3.8	0.57
Physical / embodied	15%	5.5	5.5	5.5	0.67
Human trust / accountability	15%	8.0	8.0	8.0	0.3
Regulatory / licensing	10%	7.0	7.0	7.0	0.3
Judgment under novelty	10%	7.5	7.5	7.5	0.25
				Total	5.38 → 5.4

POLICY & PROGRAM ADMINISTRATION — 6.1 (MODERATE-HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	5.3	6.5	7.4	2.59
Entry-path erosion	15%	4.0	4.5	5.0	0.75
Physical / embodied	15%	1.5	1.5	1.5	1.27
Human trust / accountability	15%	6.5	6.5	6.5	0.53
Regulatory / licensing	10%	4.0	4.0	4.0	0.6
Judgment under novelty	10%	6.5	6.5	6.5	0.35
				Total	6.09 → 6.1

4. Backcast arithmetic

Worked example for the headline track, showing exactly how the three-year movement is composed.

Statutory child protection

EDITION	A	E	PROTECTION DEFICIT (FIXED)	SCORE
2023	6.2	1.5	0.4	2.8
2025	6.9	1.8	0.4	3.1
Fall 2026	7.4	2.0	0.4	3.3

Movement decomposition: automatability contributed **+0.42** and entry-path erosion **+0.07**, for a total of **+0.5** points over three years.

The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology, not archived scores from published editions. They are our best assessment of what each factor would have rated at the time, given what was then demonstrable. They are not measurements.

5. Sensitivity

How far the score moves if a single factor is rated one point differently:

FACTOR	±1 POINT MOVES THE SCORE BY
Task automatability	±0.35
Entry-path erosion	±0.15
Physical / embodied	±0.15
Human trust / accountability	±0.15
Regulatory / licensing	±0.10
Judgment under novelty	±0.10

What this means in practice. A one-point disagreement about automatability moves a score by 0.35 — enough to shift a track between bands at the margins. A one-point disagreement about licensing moves it by 0.10, which almost never changes a band.

So if you disagree with one of our numbers, the automatability rating is where the disagreement matters most, and it is the rating we would most want challenged.

6. Stated limitations

We measure capability, not deployment. Scores reflect exposure to what AI can already do at the leading edge — not how much any particular employer has adopted. Adoption lags capability by years and lags unevenly: large, well-funded organisations first; small, rural, public-sector and thin-margin employers much later. The lag is a buffer, not a shelter. It buys time without changing direction.

We do not measure demand. A task can be highly automatable and highly in demand simultaneously. Where the labor market and our framework disagree, we say so in the profile rather than adjusting the score to fit.

We do not measure oversupply. The number of people entering a field is outside our six factors, and for some careers it matters more than automation.

We do not measure industry economics. A profession can contract for reasons entirely unrelated to technology.

We do not measure whether the work is worth doing. Pay, satisfaction, debt, hours and meaning sit outside the score and are covered separately in each profile — often at greater length, because for several careers they matter more.

Sub-track definitions are ours. Job titles vary between employers and countries. We have chosen tracks that reflect genuinely different work, not official classifications.

7. What would change our mind

Each edition names specific, checkable indicators. If these move, the scores move — including downward.

Across the index:

- **Graduate hiring share.** If employers in the professions where we rate entry-path erosion highly return to hiring juniors at pre-2023 rates, those ratings fall.
- **Content of mandated training hours.** Several professions protect their on-ramp through required supervised experience. If the content of those hours shifts from producing work to supervising it, the protection weakens without any rule changing.
- **Offsite and prefabricated construction share.** The clearest test of our physical-protection ratings: automation performs well in controlled settings, so moving work indoors raises exposure without any robotics breakthrough.

- **Verified deployment rather than capability.** If adoption stalls materially below capability for several editions, our leading-indicator approach is overstating near-term risk and we will say so.

We will report movement in either direction. A framework that only ever revises upward is not measuring anything.

Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed. The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology.